

Too close to call

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Seldom does the World Cup produce groups without a clearly defined favourite. But Group B in this edition could, in all probability, end up as a four-way tussle for two or three knockout spots.

Based solely on FIFA rankings, 19th-placed Switzerland appears ahead of the others, including Canada (30th), Qatar (55th), and Bosnia and Herzegovina (65th).

But take into account Canada's home support, Qatar's continental credentials, the wind in Bosnia's sails, and the margins quickly disappear.

Switzerland has made it out of its group in the previous two editions, but must get a hang of life without the hugely admired Yann Sommer and Xherdan Shaqiri. Ruben Vargas and

Dan Ndoye are among the emerging talismans, having set up three goals apiece during their team's qualification run.

Breel Embolo, who for long shared the burden up front with Shaqiri, has had to embrace more responsibility. Four goals in six qualifiers were evidence that he is hitting his stride.

Manuel Akanji and Ricardo Rodriguez retain the familiarity in the backline, but Fabian Schar's

absence would leave a gaping hole.

It helps that Murat Yakin has been in charge for five years now and has done well in leading this team to the last eight at the Euros. Being the highest-ranked team could be a valuable advantage for a side going through such a change.

Much has changed for Canada, too, since the last edition. The North



SWITZERLAND

FIFA ranking: 19

Appearances: 12

Best finish: Quarterfinals
(1934, 1938, 1954)

Matches: 41

Wins: 14

Draws: 8

Losses: 19

Goals For: 55

Goals Against: 73

Highest scorer in the squad
Breel Embolo (**23 goals**)



CANADA

FIFA ranking: 30

Appearances: 2

Best finish: Group stage
(1986, 2022)

Matches played: 6

Wins: 0

Draws: 0

Losses: 6

Goals For: 2

Goals Against: 12

Highest scorer in the squad
Jonathan David (**39 goals**)

